Nari Shakti Ideologue



FARZANA AFRIDI, 49
Professor and Head of Economics and Planning Unit, ISI
Delhi

Farzana Afridi was the first girl in her extended Bihari family to study abroad and earn a PhD, a remarkable achievement, considering both her grandmothers were non-literate. She gives full credit for this to her father, a government officer posted in Delhi who had big dreams for his children. Her upbringing also shaped Afridi's academic interests, the reason she chose women's economic empowerment as the central theme of her research. The 2020 recipient of the National Mahalanobis Memorial Medal for her contributions to quantitative economics, Afridi says a defining moment came in 2018 when she received a research grant from the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation. "They recognised the value of my research...it was a game-changer for my career," she says.

As her work expanded, Afridi began examining labour markets from a broader systems perspective, studying both employer and worker behaviour and the incentives that shape their decisions. Today, she is a faculty member in the Economics department at the Delhi centre of the Indian Statistical Institute (the ISI's only woman faculty in the past 15 years) while also teaching and heading a number of initiatives at other institutions. Her ongoing research focuses on the intersection of workers, enterprises and emerging technologies, and how the latter will influence existing gender gaps. Reflecting on her own journey, Afridi says that leadership has never made life less demanding. "A woman's life never stops being challenging, mine certainly hasn't," she says. ■

—Sonal Khetarpal

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Farzana's research has shaped the discourse on women's economic empowerment, labour markets and public policy in India in the past decade

HER TAKE

"Young women have to remain single-minded in their focus, seize opportunities that provide a sense of purpose beyond traditional expectations...and trust that the rest will follow"